with the agencies, Hossain purchased 59 immovable properties in Domkol in Murshidabad, Bolpur, Siuri in Birbhum, Bidhannagar and Rajarhat in Kolkata. The valuation of the properties, which include plush apartments, a palatial building in Domkol, resorts and petrol pumps, is estimated to be at least Rs 150 crore. Besides, land deeds of 121 properties registered in the names of Mondal, his family and associates have been unearthed.

Indeed, it took a long while to pin down Mondal in the cattle smuggling racket, even though alleged kingpin Enamul has been arrested twice, once by the CBI in November 2020 and now by the ED in February 2022. "Anubrata is like a king in Birbhum. Even the district judiciary is scared to give a verdict against him. It was difficult to get lawyers to fight cases against him; no police station would lodge complaints against him," alleges a resident of Bolpur in Birbhum.

From local bully to Trinamool heavyweight, Mondal's rise has been meteoric. He was quick to realise that illegal mining of sand, stones and smuggling of cattle generated big money—important for building a loyal political outfit. As he got overall charge of Birbhum, Mondal allegedly had enough left over to contribute to the party's central funds. District presidents are under considerable pressure to demonstrate their capacity for 'resource mobilisation'—their political clout depends on it. Mondal never contested an assembly or Lok Sabha election. But he ensured the TMC's victory in 11 assembly and two Lok Sabha seats. With the MLAs and MPs owing him allegiance, marshalling evidence against him was difficult. Mondal's arrest before the panchayat polls next year will certainly be a blow to the TMC. His absence is expected to give an advantage to the BJP.

Meanwhile, Enamul was arrested by the ED under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), since evidence of a long money trail stretching to foreign shores has been unearthed. According to ED officials, Enamul allegedly used to supply money to Trinamool Youth Congress leader Vinay Mishra, which would be parked abroad through hawala transactions. "Between October 2016 and March 2017, Vinay received Rs 6 crore from Enamul Haque," claims an ED official. Mishra, who was repeatedly summoned by the CBI in the smuggling probe, was once close to Abhishek Banerjee, nephew of West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee and TMC second-in-command. He is currently absconding. Asked about his party's links with the racket, TMC spokesperson Kunal Ghosh says, "A cow is neither a bird nor does it have wings. They are coming from the cow belt and take the route for which Amit Shah's BSF is responsible. They are bringing in Trinamool's name to malign it. We have evidence that (BJP MLA) Suvendu Adhikari met Vikas Mishra (Vinay's brother) in September 2021 and spoke with Vinay too."

> IT WILL TAKE **POLITICAL WILL TO SHUT DOWN THE NETWORK AS** IT INVOLVES LAKHS OF PEOPLE, BIG MONEY, AND POLITICIANS AND OFFICIALS ALLEGEDLY IN CAHOOTS WITH SMUGGLERS

### ↘ CATTLE SMUGGLING AS LIVELIHOOD

However, suspects like Mondal, Enamul and their alleged accomplices in the administration and BSF are only a few of the beneficiaries of the immense span of the cattle smuggling trade. Thousands of ordinary people depend on it for a livelihood, people who earn small amounts for errands. For instance, the idle school dropout who can earn Rs 500-600 a day for walking a pair of cattle for 10 km to a pick-up spot. Many villages in Suti, Sagardighi and Morgram in Murshidabad and Lohapur in Birbhum were involved in the operation by letting out their cowsheds for a few days to lodge cattle in before smugglers took them away at an opportune moment. "Many in our village would keep cows. The rate was Rs 50 to Rs 100 a cow for a night. Five to six cows a day fetched us good money. But when the TMC took over, there was no hide and seek. Panchayats created cow pens all along the road and made sure they enjoyed police security," says a labourer in Sagardighi. Villager Khalilur Rahaman adds, "The thud of cattle hooves all through the night would keep us awake as *rakhal*s led them to the borders stealthily. But, for over a decade now, cows are brought in small vans and trucks, because smuggling has seen a boom and it is a lot easier for local police stations to keep a track on vehicles."

Unlike in the case of former minister Partha Chatterjee, who is an accused in the teachers' recruitment scam, the TMC is backing Mondal to the hilt, for obvious reasons. At an address to TMC grassroots workers on September 8, Mamata exhorted all to give "a heroic welcome" to Mondal after his release from jail. "I will tell you one thing, *ghaas katle aro baare* (the more you cut grass, the more it grows). Similarly, the more CBI, ED uses scissors on us, the more we'll grow," she said.

However, observers say cattle smuggling is just too elaborate an operation to be wound down soon. "It is a big chain and the network involves lakhs of people in Birbhum and Murshidabad. It cannot break that easily, since huge money is involved and big men are on the payroll," says political analyst Sobhonlal Dutta Gupta. The solution will have to be sought elsewhere. ■